Token and cost estimation

SIFT

How many tokens each model call uses, what that costs on the models the project is set to call, and what the same work would cost on the other current models.

27 October 2026 · List prices from Anthropic and Google · A typical CV and a typical interview, reconstructed from the prompts in the code

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1. Purpose

This document answers two questions. How many tokens does each call in Sift consume? If that call is sent to a different model, including the models the project is configured to use, what does it cost?

The running application does not save the token counts returned by Anthropic or Google. Every number here is rebuilt from the prompt the code actually sends, the caps on those prompts, and a typical CV and interview of the size the product was built for. A provider invoice is the authority for a real month. This document is the map of where that invoice comes from.

Money is in US dollars. A token is the unit the model vendor bills. For this English text, one token is about four characters. A page of a CV is roughly 400 to 700 tokens.

2. How a figure was counted

Each call has a system instruction and a task. Both are input tokens. The JSON or prose the model returns is output tokens. The bill is:

> cost = (input tokens ÷ 1,000,000 × input price) + (output tokens ÷ 1,000,000 × output price)

Worked example, one checklist item on Claude Sonnet 4.6, at the typical size used below (2,200 input tokens and 80 output tokens):

> (2,200 ÷ 1,000,000 × $3) + (80 ÷ 1,000,000 × $15) = $0.0066 + $0.0012 = $0.0078

The typical size assumes a CV of about 6,000 characters (roughly two to three pages) and spoken answers of about 120 words. Several prompts also have a hard cap. When a CV fills the 12,000-character cap, the screening input is about one and a half to two times the typical figure. Section 13 states each cap.

Output is what the model actually writes. Claude is allowed up to 4,096 tokens on an ordinary call, and a live interview reply is capped at 200 tokens. The tables use the size of a normal JSON answer, which is well under those ceilings.

Sift does not turn on prompt caching, so the cheaper cache-read rates are not used. A failed retry can bill a second time. The tables are the happy path: one successful request per call.

3. Which model answers

The names are the defaults in `backend/app/core/config.py` and `.env.example`. An environment variable with the same name replaces the default.

Role	Setting	Default model	When it is asked
First	`ANTHROPIC_MODEL`	claude-sonnet-4-6	Every ordinary completion
Second	`GEMINI_MODEL`	gemini-3.5-flash-lite	If Claude fails, and every spoken interview turn
Local	`OLLAMA_MODEL`	llama3.2	If both paid models fail, and two calls that never leave the machine

3.1 Ordinary completions

`FallbackLLMManager.complete` tries Claude, then Gemini, then Ollama. The first model that returns text is the one that is billed. If the Claude key is empty, that tier stops before any network call, and the desk work is billed to Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite.

3.2 Spoken interview turns

`complete_live` asks Gemini only. Claude is not tried. If Gemini misses the five-second limit, the turn is not handed to another model. A short spoken pause is used instead. There is no charge for that pause.

3.3 Local-only calls

`complete_local` asks Ollama only. That is the skill recheck after CV screening, and the two-sentence summary of an uploaded company policy. Both are $0 at the API.

4. Prices used

List prices on 27 October 2026, standard paid tier, per million tokens. Gemini's output price includes thinking tokens. Flash-Lite's default thinking level is minimal, so the visible JSON is close to the billed output. A thinking model can bill several times the text you see.

Model	Input	Output	Place in Sift
Claude Sonnet 4.6	$3.00	$15.00	First model for ordinary calls
Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite	$0.30	$2.50	Second model, and the live voice
Ollama llama3.2	$0	$0	Local recheck and policy summary

Section 12 prices the same token counts on other models a project might switch to. Those prices are from the same vendor pages.

5. Calls that set up a role

Creating a job runs two model calls, then checks the JSON in code. Policy excerpts are retrieved with a local embedding model before the first call. That retrieval has no API charge. The two calls below are ordinary completions: Sonnet 4.6 when Claude answers, Flash-Lite when the call falls through.

Call	What is sent	Input	Output	Sonnet 4.6	Flash-Lite
Job description	Title, skills, years, and the policy excerpts	1,200	600	$0.013	$0.002
Ten checklist queries	The new description, plus the instruction to write Q1–Q10	1,000	1,500	$0.026	$0.004
One draft		**2,200**	**2,100**	**$0.038**	**$0.006**

Asking the desk copilot to draft a role adds one copilot call (section 8) in front of these two.

6. Calls that screen a CV

This is the largest part of the bill. One CV produces eleven ordinary model calls, and sometimes one free local call. The ten checklist calls each send the CV again. The code allows 12,000 characters of CV text and 4,000 characters of excerpts on every one of those ten calls.

Call	How often	Input	Output	Sonnet 4.6	Flash-Lite
Read name, email, skills, jobs, education	Once	1,800	500	$0.013	$0.002
Score one checklist item	Ten times	2,200	80	$0.008	$0.001
Ten checklist items together	Once per CV	22,000	800	$0.078	$0.009
Local skill recheck	Once, when an item is unmet or partial	3,000	200	$0	$0
One CV, typical		**23,800**	**1,300**	**$0.091**	**$0.010**

The total row is the extract plus the ten scores. The recheck is extra tokens and no money. The similarity between the CV and each question is a local MiniLM embedding, computed before the ten scores, and it is not in this table.

A CV that fills the 12,000-character cap raises one checklist call from about 2,200 input tokens to about 4,300. Ten such calls are about 43,000 input tokens, about $0.14 on Sonnet 4.6 or about $0.014 on Flash-Lite, before the extract.

Ranking, the must-have ratio, and the three dimension scores are arithmetic on the ten statuses. They add no tokens.

7. Calls during and after the interview

The figures are for one person who sits the agent-conducted interview, takes the quiz, and receives a written assessment. A human-run interview uses the in-call copilot in section 8 instead of the spoken turns.

7.1 The agent that conducts the interview

The opening sentence is fixed text. It is written in code and spoken by the local voice. It is not a model call. After that, every time the candidate's words are ready, Gemini is asked for one short JSON reply: what kind of thing they just did, and the next sentence to speak. The system instruction is about 1,000 tokens and is sent again on every turn. The task adds the company, the role, up to 2,500 characters of CV profile, the checklist, and the last 12 lines of the transcript.

A clean interview covers about ten checklist topics and needs a few extra turns for a fragment, a question, or the close. The roll-up uses 14 turns. A quiet interview can be nearer 10. A talkative one can pass 25. Early turns are smaller. Late turns, with twelve transcript lines, are nearer 3,000 input tokens. The average used here is 2,150 in and 120 out.

Call	Model	Input	Output	Cost
One spoken turn	Flash-Lite only	2,150	120	$0.001
Fourteen spoken turns	Flash-Lite only	30,100	1,680	$0.013

If the first request is still running after 1.5 seconds, the code sends a second copy and keeps whichever returns first. A spoken line often takes longer than 1.5 seconds, so a turn can be billed twice. Fourteen doubled turns are about $0.026 instead of $0.013. Section 13 treats this as the main uncertainty on the live bill.

Hearing the candidate is local faster-whisper. Speaking the line is local Kokoro, with Piper only if Kokoro cannot load. Neither is in the table.

7.2 The quiz, the claims, and the scores

These are ordinary completions. They run once per interviewed person. Quiz marking is a comparison of the chosen option with the stored answer. The six interview weights are applied in code. The model only copies short quotes.

Call	What is sent	Input	Output	Sonnet 4.6	Flash-Lite
Write the ten-question quiz	Checklist, plus up to 3,500 characters of CV	1,800	1,400	$0.026	$0.004
Extract claims from the CV	Up to 12,000 characters of CV	1,800	600	$0.014	$0.002
Compare claims with the interview	The claims, plus up to 12,000 characters of speech	3,000	400	$0.015	$0.002
Copy one quote per dimension	Checklist and the candidate's speech	2,500	200	$0.011	$0.001

7.3 Question-and-answer analysis

After the call, seven ordinary completions read the same pairs. Each question and each answer is clipped at 1,200 characters. Ten pairs of a typical length are about 2,600 input tokens per pass.

Pass	What it returns	Input	Output
1	An intent label for each question	2,600	150
2–5	A score for relevance, technical accuracy, completeness, then articulation	10,400	800
6	Which checklist items each answer covered	2,600	150
7	A short justification with citations copied from the transcript	2,600	400
Seven passes		**18,200**	**1,500**

On Sonnet 4.6 the seven passes are $0.077. On Flash-Lite they are $0.009. Gaps and score disagreements after that are computed in code.

7.4 The written assessment

Two ordinary completions. The suitability percentage, the 30/20/50 mix, and the evidence gaps are computed in code. The model writes the strengths, the weaknesses, and the narrative, and it has to copy its citations from a catalog the code already built.

Call	Input	Output	Sonnet 4.6	Flash-Lite
Strengths and weaknesses	2,000	400	$0.012	$0.002
Narrative	2,000	400	$0.012	$0.002
Both	**4,000**	**800**	**$0.024**	**$0.003**

8. Calls from the recruiter’s desk

Each message to the desk copilot is one ordinary completion. The system instruction is about 600 tokens. The task is the conversation so far, so a long chat grows. A short turn is the size below. The service then runs the action itself. Approving a job and polling the inbox are confirmation chips. The model is not asked to do those.

Call	Input	Output	Sonnet 4.6	Flash-Lite
One desk message	800	200	$0.005	$0.001
Thirty desk messages	24,000	6,000	$0.162	$0.022

Comparing two stored people is one ordinary completion. The prompt is the scores and the written strengths, not the CVs. About 1,000 input tokens and 250 output tokens: $0.007 on Sonnet 4.6, or $0.001 on Flash-Lite.

The in-call copilot, used while a person is still running the interview, is a separate assistant. One click sends the CV profile (capped at 6,000 characters), the checklist, and the transcript. The transcript on that path has no character cap, so a long call, clicked often, is the desk call most likely to grow past the figures in this document. A mid-call click is on the order of 3,000 to 8,000 input tokens and about 200 output tokens.

Uploading a company policy embeds the chunks locally, then asks Ollama for two sentences from the first 3,600 characters. That summary is about 1,000 input tokens and 80 output tokens, at $0.

9. Work with no API charge

These run on the machine that hosts Sift. They use CPU, memory, and disk. They do not appear on an Anthropic or Google invoice.

Work	What runs it
Policy and CV similarity	Local MiniLM embeddings, 384 dimensions
Hearing the candidate	faster-whisper, default model “base”, on CPU
Speaking the interview	Kokoro by default, Piper if Kokoro cannot load
Face check	InsightFace, model buffalo_l
Raising an unmet skill	Ollama llama3.2
Policy summary	Ollama llama3.2
Quiz marking, ranking, suitability mix, invite selection	Application code

10. One finished candidate

A finished candidate has a screened CV, an agent-conducted interview of 14 spoken turns, a quiz, a claim check, question-and-answer analysis, and a written assessment. The job draft and the recruiter's chat are not included. They belong to the role, not to the person.

The first money column is the path the code takes when Claude answers the ordinary calls and Gemini answers the spoken turns. The second column is the same tokens if Flash-Lite answers every paid call, which is what happens when the Claude key is empty.

Piece	Input	Output	Sonnet, live on Flash-Lite	All Flash-Lite
Read the CV	1,800	500	$0.013	$0.002
Ten checklist scores	22,000	800	$0.078	$0.009
Extract claims	1,800	600	$0.014	$0.002
Compare claims with speech	3,000	400	$0.015	$0.002
Write the quiz	1,800	1,400	$0.026	$0.004
Fourteen spoken turns	30,100	1,680	$0.013	$0.013
Evidence quotes	2,500	200	$0.011	$0.001
Seven analysis passes	18,200	1,500	$0.077	$0.009
Strengths and narrative	4,000	800	$0.024	$0.003
Paid total	**85,200**	**7,880**	**$0.27**	**$0.045**

Of the $0.27, about $0.26 is Sonnet 4.6 (55,100 input tokens and 6,200 output tokens) and about $0.013 is the live Flash-Lite turns. The local recheck adds about 3,000 tokens at $0.

Screening alone, before anyone is interviewed, is the first two rows: about $0.09 on Sonnet 4.6, or about $0.01 on Flash-Lite.

When the live hedge fires and the second copy is billed, add about $0.013. The candidate is then about $0.28.

11. A day of hiring

One job draft, twenty CVs screened, five of those people taken through the full interview, thirty desk-copilot messages, and three side-by-side comparisons. This is a working day of the size the product has been exercised at. It is not a capacity limit.

Work	Sonnet, live on Flash-Lite	All Flash-Lite
One job draft	$0.04	$0.006
Twenty CVs screened	$1.82	$0.20
Five full interviews, on top of screening	$0.90	$0.17
Thirty desk messages	$0.16	$0.02
Three comparisons	$0.02	$0.003
Day	**about $3**	**about $0.40**

The twenty CVs dominate the Sonnet bill, because each CV repeats its text across ten checklist calls. The five interviews are the next largest piece. The desk chat is small beside either of those.

12. The same work on other models

The token counts are the finished candidate from section 10: 85,200 input tokens and 7,880 output tokens, of which the 14 spoken turns are 30,100 input and 1,680 output. For a Claude model, the spoken turns stay on Flash-Lite, because that is what `complete_live` calls. The “all on this model” column is the cost if the project were pointed entirely at that model, including the spoken turns.

Model	Input / million	Output / million	One candidate
Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite, every call	$0.10	$0.40	$0.012
Claude Haiku 5.5 for the desk, Flash-Lite for the call	$0.10	$0.50	$0.022
Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite, every call	$0.30	$2.50	$0.045
Gemini 2.5 Flash, every call	$0.30	$2.50	$0.045
Claude Haiku 4.5 for the desk, Flash-Lite for the call	$1.00	$5.00	$0.10
Claude Sonnet 5.5 for the desk, Flash-Lite for the call	$2.00	$10.00	$0.19
Claude Sonnet 4.6 for the desk, Flash-Lite for the call	$3.00	$15.00	$0.27
Claude Opus 4.6 for the desk, Flash-Lite for the call	$5.00	$25.00	$0.44

Haiku 5.5’s $0.10 / $0.50 rate applies to prompts under 100,000 tokens. Every call in this document is under that line. Gemini 2.5 Flash has the same list price as Flash-Lite, and its thinking tokens are billed as output, so a real run can cost more than $0.045. Sonnet 4.6 is the first model the code tries today. Flash-Lite is the model the interview speaks with today.

The same order, for the day in section 11, scales roughly with these candidate prices. Twenty screened CVs and five interviews on Sonnet 4.6 are about $3. The same day entirely on Flash-Lite is about $0.40. Entirely on Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite it would be about $0.10, before any thinking-token overhead on a model that has it.

13. What changes the bill

The tables are a typical case. These are the levers already present in the code.

Lever	Where	Effect
CV repeated ten times	Checklist scoring, each item sends the CV and excerpts	Most of the screening cost. A full 12,000-character CV is about twice the typical screening input.
Live hedge	A second Gemini request after 1.5 seconds, five-second deadline, 200-token cap	Can double the live-turn input. About one extra cent per candidate at Flash-Lite prices.
Number of spoken turns	About one model call per thing the candidate says	Linear. Twenty-five turns instead of fourteen adds about one cent on Flash-Lite.
Thinking tokens	Billed as output on Gemini thinking models	Flash-Lite's default is minimal. Gemini 2.5 Flash can multiply the output bill.
In-call copilot transcript	The human interviewer's assistant sends the transcript with no character cap	Grows with the length of the call and with how often it is clicked.
Retries	Gemini ordinary calls retry up to three times on 429, 500, and 503	A request that was processed and then failed can be billed again.
Empty Claude key	The Claude tier returns before the network call	Desk work moves from the $0.27 column to the $0.045 column.
Prompt caching	Not enabled	The repeated system text and the repeated CV are billed in full on every call.

Caps that bound the input, so a single call cannot grow without limit:

- CV text on extract, checklist scoring, claim extract, and the local recheck: 12,000 characters. Excerpts on a checklist item: 4,000 characters.
- CV profile on a spoken turn: 2,500 characters. Transcript on a spoken turn: the last 12 lines.
- Quiz CV excerpt: 3,500 characters.
- Question-and-answer text: 1,200 characters for a question and 1,200 for an answer.
- In-call copilot profile: 6,000 characters. Interview speech on the quote and claim-compare prompts: 12,000 characters.
- Policy summary: the first 3,600 characters, and the reply is trimmed to about 480 characters.
- Live output: 200 tokens. Ordinary Claude output: at most 4,096 tokens, billed only for what is written.

14. Limits of this estimate

The figures are typical sizes, not a meter reading. A provider's usage page is the record of what was spent. This document will drift if a prompt is lengthened or a model name in the environment is changed.

Prices are the public list rates on 27 October 2026 for the standard paid tier. Batch discounts, regional multipliers, and cache reads are not applied, because the code does not use them. Free-tier quotas, when a vendor still offers them, can make a small test cost nothing until the quota is spent. That quota is a vendor limit, not a property of Sift.

Local models still have a machine cost: whisper, Kokoro, MiniLM, InsightFace, and Ollama use CPU, memory, and disk on the host. That cost is not converted into dollars here, because it depends on the machine rather than on a

token price.